BIGBY PRESENTS

GLORY OF THE GIANTS™



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12+

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On the Cover

Bigby's grasping hand steals a giant goose's golden egg from its cloud giant keepers in this painting by Cynthia Sheppard.



On the Alt-Cover

Bigby plays chess—a game whose Giant name translates to "war of the stone kings"—with a stone giant in this cover by Olena Richards.

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Contents

Diancastra's Saga 4
Glory of the Giants 5
Annam and the Giants 6
Giantkind 7
Giants of Many Worlds 8

Ch.1: Character Creation 11
Subclass Option 11
Barbarian: Path of the Giant 11
Backgrounds 12
Bonus Feats 12
Giant Foundling 12
Rune Carver 14
Big Heroes, Big Stories 15
Heroes of the Giants 15
Birthplaces and Hometowns 16
Tall Tales 17
Feats 17
Feat Descriptions 17

Ch. 2: Giants in Play 21
Roleplaying Giants 21
Size 21
Age 22
Volume 22
Pride 22
Names 23
The Ordning 24
Rejecting the Ordning 26
Origin of the Ordning 26
Gods and Religion 27
Annam and the Ordning 27
Interloper Gods 31
Gods and Adventures 33
Social Structures 34
Recluse 35
Exile 35
Band 36
Family 37
Steading 37
Settlement 38
Organizations 39
Hidden Rune 39
Stewards of the Eternal Throne 40
Worldroot Circle 41

Ch. 3: Giant Adventures 43
Encounters 43
Using the Tables 43
Giantkind Encounters 44
Connected Creatures 48
Adventures 55
Adventure Models 55
Giant Patrons 59
Campaigns 62
A World of Giants 62
Campaign Events 62
Giants and Other Ancients 63
Giants of Myth 65

Ch. 4: Giant Enclaves 67
Using Enclaves 67
Giant Enclave General Features 67
Annam's Cradle 68
Ashen Grotto 70
Dreamer's Reach 72
Endless Rockslide 74
Forest Crystal 76
Forsaken Deep 78
Gale's Eye Tower 80
Grolantor's Larder 82
Hiatea's Hearth 84
Horizon's Edge 86
Howling Iceberg 88
Karontor's Hold 90
Misty Vale 92
Runic Circle 94
Singing Sands 96
Star Forge 98
Thundering Observatory 100
Worldroot Sapling 102

Ch. 5: Giant Treasures 105
Giant Bags 105
Cloud Giant Bags 105
Fire Giant Bags 106
Frost Giant Bags 106
Hill Giant Bags 107
Stone Giant Bags 107
Storm Giant Bags 108
Relics of Giant Realms 108
Kinds of Treasure 108
Magic Items 110
A Note About Size 110
Giant-Crafted Items 110
Magic Item Descriptions 110

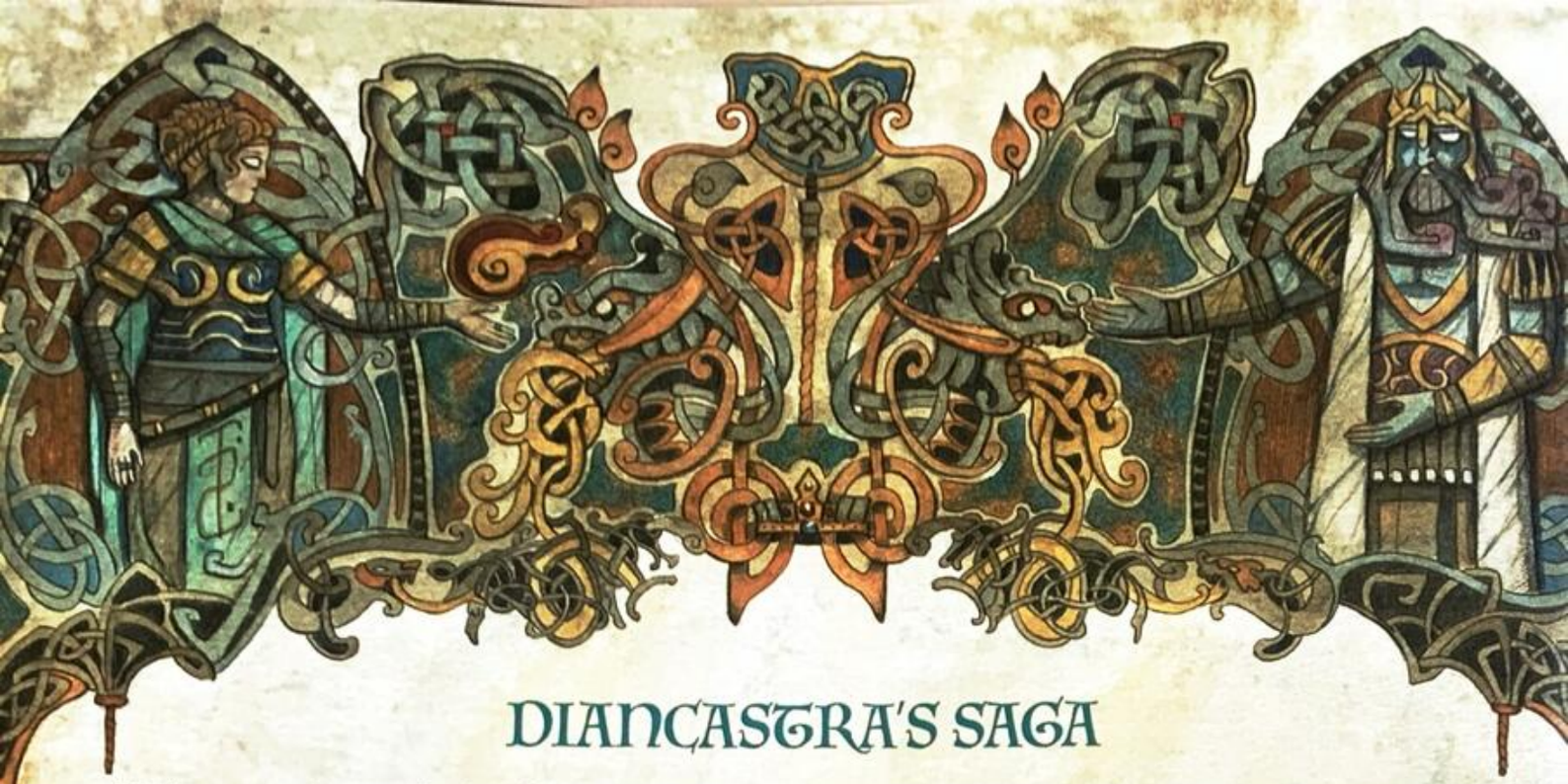
Ch. 6: Bestiary 119
Bag Jelly 120
Barrowghast 121
Cairnwight 122
Cinder Hulk 123
Cloud Giant Destiny Gambler 124
Cloud Giant of Evil Air 125
Death Giants 126
Death Giant Reaper 126
Death Giant Shrouded One 127
Dinosaurs 128
Aerosaur 128
Altisaur 129
Ceratops 129
Regisaur 130
Dust Hulk 131
Echo of Demogorgon 132
Ettin Ceremorph 133
Fensirs 134
Fensir Devourer 135
Fensir Skirmisher 135
Firbolgs 136
Firbolg Primeval Warden 136
Firbolg Wanderer 137
Firegaunt 137
Fire Giant Forgecaller 138
Fire Giant of Evil Fire 139
Fire Hellion 140
Flesh Colossus 141
Fomorians 142
Fomorian Deep Crawler 142
Fomorian Noble 143
Fomorian Warlock of the Dark 144
Frost Giant Ice Shaper 145
Frost Giant of Evil Water 146
Frostmourn 147
Fury of Kostchtchie 148
Gargantua 149
Giant Goose 150
Giant Lynx 151
Giant Ox 152
Giant Ram 153
Giant Tick 153
Gigant 154
Goliath Giant-Kin 155
Grinning Cat 156
Hill Giant Avalancher 157
Lightning Hulk 158
Maw of Yeenoghu 159
Mist Hulk 160
Mud Hulk 161
Rime Hulk 162
Runic Colossus 163
Scions of Giants' Gods 164
Cradle of the Hill Scion 164
Scion of Grolantor 165
Cradle of the Cloud Scion 166
Scion of Memnor 167
Cradle of the Stone Scion 168
Scion of Skoraeus 169
Cradle of the Storm Scion 170
Scion of Stronmaus 171
Cradle of the Fire Scion 172
Scion of Surtur 173
Cradle of the Frost Scion 174
Scion of Thrym 175
Spectral Cloud 176
Spotted Lion 177
Stalker of Baphomet 178
Stone Giant of Evil Earth 179
Stone Giant Rockspeaker 180
Storm Crab 181
Storm Giant Tempest Caller 182
Storm Herald 183
Tempest Spirit 184
Titanothere 185
Trolls 186
Troll Amalgam 186
Troll Mutate 187
Creature Lists 188
Giants by Kind 188
Challenge Ratings 188
Creature Types 189

Appendix A: Concept Art 190

Appendix B: Adventure Hooks 192

Sidebars

The Many Meanings of "Giant" 7
Giant Runes and Dwarvish Script 9
Giant Children 34
Giants and Tiers of Play 44
Pick a Giant, Any Giant 46
Entering Horizon's Edge 86
Giant-Crafted Items 110
Destiny Gambler Spell Winnings 125



DIANCASTRA'S SAGA

Battle-worn and weary, bruised from her journey,
Diancastra entered the All-Father's hall.
With calm confidence she claimed her due
Under the birthright of her blood:
  Her father's gift of godliness.

"Wise one, All-Father Annam, world-shaper of old,
Mighty were your deeds in time's dawning.
You scattered seeds of the sundered First World;
Your dreams created the cosmos,
  The teeming worlds, full of wonders.

"Six sons, goddess-born, you sanctioned as rulers
To govern the mortal multitudes.
Boorish and bumbling, they bungled the task!
Surely I am more deserving of divinity
  In spite of my mortal mother."

Scowling, all-wise Annam spoke to his daughter:
"Mighty are my sons in strength,
And Hiatea, your half sister, her heroism showed
In slaying a many-headed monster.
  What such deeds have you done?"

"The sphinx's riddles I solved to claim her prize.
I plumbed the secrets of the sea.
I ventured to the vault of the venerated lobster-god
To steal her precious pearls—
  And I found your secret sanctum."

"Pranks and rebellion! Prove your worth
Not with the willful choices of a child.
I will test your temper; try this challenge:
Bring me pure perfection—
  Something my craft cannot better."

Diancastra, undaunted, departed the sanctum
And journeyed to the waters beyond worlds.
She sailed forgotten seas into storms of chaos
And claimed a mote of matter,
  Shapeless, unformed, and ever-changing.

The All-Father mocked her and easily shaped it,
Making a fertile field.
But soon he scowled, not satisfied, and reshaped it
Into a storm-tossed sea,
  Then a fiery furnace-peak.

At last, Diancastra, laughing, said to him,
"Forsake your cunning craft!
Chaos is a canvas for creation, unbounded,
Perfectly imperfect and unformed.
  You cannot perfect potential."

Laughter filled Annam's hall, loud as thunder,
Shaking floor and firmament.
The All-Father acquiesced, admitting defeat,
And granted Diancastra's demand,
  Kindling the god-spark he gave her.

"Too bitterly I judged the bungling of my sons,
In haste I quickly condemned them.
I will watch them and see whether perhaps they too
Share your clever capacity
  To see perfection in potential."

A crown he then made, from chaos he shaped it,
And to her he gratefully gave it.
Divine Diancastra departed his sanctum,
With stirrings of hope for her harried kin,
  The All-Father's favor foreseen.

Dear reader,

This book represents a journey for me, and I am excited to take your hand and lead you along the same path. I never had much interest in giants, though I certainly respected their strength. My various encounters with Diancastra—who is no less than a daughter of Annam, the All-Father of the giants!—opened my eyes to the glories, the deep magic, and the wisdom of these ancient people.

I've asked Diancastra to review this text, and her notes appear throughout the book where her perspective can enlarge upon my own. I trust that her insight and my erudition will expand your horizons as she has broadened mine.

—Bigby



Glory of the Giants

Myths, fairy tales, folklore, and fantasy literature throughout the real world depict a tremendous range of giants. Some tales suggest that the humans of past ages were gigantic, and the relatively small stature of present-day humans is a mark of their degeneracy. Others imagine remote realms—cloud castles or lost continents—where Brobdingnagian people dwell, set apart from their puny relatives.

In the worlds of Dungeons & Dragons, the story of the giants is a tragic one that echoes this whole range of fantasy and myth. Begotten by the mighty god Annam, who intended them to rule the worlds with wisdom as well as might, giants have fallen far short of the lofty destiny their progenitor imagined for them. Now supplanted by myriad smaller peoples of the worlds, giants live apart in remote steadings, undersea palaces, subterranean realms, and flying citadels.

Bigby Presents: Glory of the Giants explores giants' role in D&D and their realms across the worlds. It delves into the history of the giants and details the places where they live in isolation, as well as the ruins they left behind in their decline. Our guide in this exploration is the wizard Bigby, a former apprentice of Mordenkainen and creator of the spell *Bigby's hand*. Though he began his career determined to use magic to dominate and control others, he eventually changed his ways and has worked hard to make amends for his past villainy. One factor that influenced his change of heart was Bigby's recurring encounters with Diancastra, a demigod revered by many giants. Throughout this book, we see glimpses into the relationship between these two mighty figures of legend.

This introduction presents a portion of the saga of Diancastra. The saga is a window into important aspects of giants' life and thought, and it introduces themes that reappear throughout the book: Annam's retreat from his children, the giants' fall from grace, and the hope some giants hold for a future restoration of their ancient glory.

Chapter 1 introduces giant-themed options for adventurers, including a subclass that allows characters to tap into the magic of giants (the Path of the Giant barbarian), two giant-related backgrounds (the giant foundling and the rune carver), and a wide selection of feats. The chapter also includes roleplaying suggestions to help you connect a character of any class to the grandeur of giants.

Chapter 2 offers advice and tables to help Dungeon Masters use giants in play. It covers roleplaying tips, an overview of the hierarchical structure of the ordning and giants' religion, and ideas about giants' organizations and societies.

FRANCESCA BAERALD (L), ROBSON MICHEL (R)

Chapter 3 presents tools to help Dungeon Masters build encounters, adventures, and whole campaigns around giants. The chapter includes tables you can use to populate the giants' enclaves presented in chapter 4.

Chapter 4 discusses the places where giants dwell: the remote enclaves and secret hideaways where they cling to the remnants of their ancient glory. Maps are a centerpiece of the chapter, presenting a range of sites steeped in giants' supernatural power that you can drop into any campaign.

Chapter 5 details the treasures characters might find as they deal with giants or explore giants' hidden realms. These treasures range from the contents of a wandering giant's bag to the mightiest relics of giants' ancient civilization. The chapter includes more than two dozen new magic items.

Chapter 6 provides stat blocks and lore for a tremendous variety of giants. The chapter includes new giant kinds (such as the death giant) and new variations on the giants found in the *Monster Manual*. A range of other enormous creatures, from towering dinosaurs to magical giant geese, can help DMs populate a giant-sized environment.

Annam and the Giants

The saga of the demigod Diancastra is an epic poem treasured by skalds and storytellers among all kinds of giants. The portion of the saga excerpted at the start of this book is among its most popular scenes, describing how Diancastra convinced her father to imbue her with divinity even though her mother was a mortal giant.

The story is unusual among the sagas of the giants in its description of Annam's deeds "in time's dawning." It boldly claims Annam collected the fragments of the First World—the original world of the Material Plane, created by the primordial dragons Bahamut and Tiamat—and contributed in some way to their transformation into the Material Plane as it exists today with its myriad worlds. Other sagas claim Annam was similarly instrumental in the creation of the Inner Planes, slowly sorting the tumult of the Elemental Chaos until the four Elemental Planes took shape. These sagas explain the giants' close ties to the elemental forces of air, earth, fire, and water by pointing to Annam's early efforts in the Elemental Planes.

Diancastra's Saga also summarizes the central tragedy of giantkind's long history: Annam intended the giants to rule over all the worlds of the Material Plane, but his six sons—the gods Stronmaus, Memnor, Surtur, Thrym, Skoraeus, and Grolantor—failed to live up to their father's expectations for them. (Diancastra calls her brothers "boorish and bumbling." Notably, Annam does not refute her on that point.) Annam's disappointment in his sons caused him to retreat to a hidden realm within the Outlands, far removed from the Material Plane and the domains of other gods.

A key moment in *Diancastra's Saga* is Annam's challenge to his daughter. He dismisses her deeds as "pranks and rebellion" and defies Diancastra to bring him "pure perfection," some item that for all his craft and skill he is unable to improve. He clearly intends this to be an impossible task.

But Diancastra surprises him. Journeying to the outermost reaches of the Elemental Chaos, where unshaped elements form a tumult of matter and energy, she claims a mote of raw chaos and brings it to her father. Annam quickly shapes it, but he is unsatisfied with the result; he shapes it again and again, but—as Diancastra points out—each of his efforts to craft something from the chaos ends up reducing its raw potential into mere actuality.

The saga makes a point that concerns more than Diancastra's cleverness. In granting his daughter's request for divinity, Annam acknowledges that the same chaotic, changeable potential exists within his sons and their descendants. Ultimately, this acknowledgment holds out the possibility that Annam's faith in his descendants might be restored and the All-Father might one day be drawn from his self-imposed exile. That glimmer of hope, faint as it might be, is a significant motivation for those giants who hope to reclaim their people's ancient glory, and it might account for the saga's popularity among giants of all kinds.

A good saga, well-told, reveals a great deal about the teller. If you're lucky and self-aware, it can also show you something about yourself. Only rarely does it tell you much worth knowing about its subject among its alliteration and kennings and such. That said, Bigby presented me with several versions of my saga, and I insisted he use this one. The interpretation he presents here is a reasonable one.

—Diancastra

Giantkind

The descendants of Annam are the various creatures of the Giant creature type. The precise details of genealogy linking Annam to these Giants are a matter of mythology, and myths vary from world to world and from one teller to another. Most tellings make a distinction between the main families of giants who are descended from the sons of Annam and the various other creatures whose origins are murkier.

Heirs of Annam

As described in the *Monster Manual*, the ordning ranks the six main families of giants. Each family's place in the ordning corresponds to the birth order of the associated son of Annam: Stronmaus, Annam's firstborn, is regarded as the progenitor of storm giants, and Grolantor, progenitor of hill giants, is Annam's youngest son. Thus, the ordning neatly encompasses and arranges storm giants, cloud giants, fire giants, frost giants, stone giants, and hill giants by connecting them to Stronmaus, Memnor, Surtur, Thrym, Skoraeus, and Grolantor, respectively.

That neat structure overlooks the daughters of Annam: Hiatea, Iallanis, and Diancastra. Indeed, these goddesses and their worshipers often push against the boundaries of the ordning, both within each kind of giant and in the overall rankings of the giant families. No giants count the goddesses as ancestors, but that helps ensure their popularity extends across giantkind.

Fomorians. The structure of the ordning also overlooks the fomorians and their progenitor, Karontor, who is usually described as Grolantor's older twin. Just as Annam banished Karontor from the family of the gods for his part in inciting the fomorians to assault the Feywild, the All-Father also excluded the fomorians from the ordning.

Death Giants. Once cloud giants, death giants (introduced in chapter 6 of this book) technically have the same rank in the ordning as the other descendants of Memnor. However, by turning away from the gods of their ancestors to serve the Raven Queen, they have abdicated their place in the ordning.

Other Giants

The other creatures of the Giant type, who are not included in the category of "giants," are connected to Annam but not descended from him.

Trolls and Ogres. The monstrous god Vaprak is connected to Annam in some myths, though he is never regarded as a proper son of Annam. The Dwarvish *Saga of Gnarldan Steelshield* describes how Vaprak arose from Annam's blood when it was spilled on one of the worlds he tended, and the trolls in turn arose from Vaprak's blood shed in a similar manner. The fensirs introduced in chapter 6 of this book are descended from trolls. Ogres are sometimes described as descendants of Vaprak, giving them a distant and distorted connection to Annam. Oni are often said to be distantly related to ogres, but at this point they are more fiendish than Giant.

Cyclopes. Contradictory legends explain the origin of cyclopes, and none of those legends are told by cyclopes themselves (who generally display little interest in the question of their origins and their connection to the gods). Some myths lump them in with ogres as descendants of Vaprak, while others claim they were once ogres who joined the ancient fomorians' invasion of the Feywild and thus shared in fomorians' banishment to the Underdark and the resulting corruption of their physical forms. One myth suggests cyclopes are descendants of Karontor like the fomorians, but stemming from a line that began after Karontor's banishment rather than before it.

Ettins. A widespread folktale suggests ettins were once orcs who were transformed into their giant-like form by a blessing of the demon lord Demogorgon. If that were true, though, ettins would have no connection to Annam and couldn't be considered kin of the giants. Most giants acknowledge ettins as distant relatives and consider them descendants of Grolantor (and thus distant cousins of hill giants) or of hill giants who were transformed by Demogorgon.

The Many Meanings of "Giant"

The word "giant" has multiple meanings in English and in the rules of D&D, opening the possibility of some confusion.

As a rule, when this book talks about "giants," it refers to the various creatures that include "giant" in their name—specifically, the giants found in the *Monster Manual*—cloud giants, fire giants, frost giants, hill giants, stone giants, and storm giants—as well as the death giants that appear in chapter 6 of this book. These giants are the focus of this book, so it's safe to assume that's what is meant when you see the word "giant" and it's not capitalized or otherwise qualified.

"Giant" is also a creature type in the D&D rules, and as such, it's capitalized whenever it's used. This book usually refers to "creatures of the Giant type" to make sure it's very clear what is being talked about. All the giants are creatures of the Giant type, as are cyclopes, ettins, fomorians, ogres, and trolls. But that latter group of creatures is not the focus of this book.

"Giant" (capitalized) is also the name of the language spoken by most creatures of the Giant type (as well as a few other creatures, such as hags). References to the language throughout this book typically refer to "the Giant language" or "Giant runes," so there should be no confusion between the language and the creature type.

Goliaths and Firbolgs

In addition to all these creatures classed as Giants, two Humanoid kinds also claim distant kinship to Annam's heirs. Goliaths and firbolgs appear in chapter 6 of this book and also appear as character races in *Mordenkainen Presents: Monsters of the Multiverse*. Their connection to Annam is undoubtedly distant, but some individuals among both peoples hold giants in high regard and even worship the divine children of Annam—especially his daughters.

Giants of Many Worlds

The saga of Diancastra hints that giants' presence throughout myriad worlds of the Material Plane might be attributable to Annam's role in the shaping of those worlds. Giants believe they were meant to rule the worlds of the Material Plane, and on many worlds, historical records show they once did. But their glory days are in the inconceivably ancient past, long before any smaller folk ever dreamed of writing histories.

Forgotten Realms

The origins of the giants on the world of Toril lie far in the past, long before any Humanoid peoples proliferated. According to the giants' sagas, Annam fathered the first giants and guided his sons in establishing an empire called Ostoria. In the sagas, this age is called the Time of Giants.

The age is also called the Time of Dragons, because dragons arose and flourished in the same period. Some say the giants were able to build Ostoria only because conflict among the dragons left power vacuums the giants filled.

After four millennia of coexistence and intermittent conflict, a mighty red dragon named Garyx—sometimes seen as a god among dragons—goaded the dragons into war with the giants of Ostoria. The conflict is remembered as the Thousand-Year War, though it almost certainly involved long periods of quiet interrupted by battles of intense savagery and widespread destruction. By the end of this conflict, Ostoria was reduced to a shadow of its former glory—and Annam turned his back on his descendants in disappointment.

For nearly thirty thousand years since the fall of Ostoria, giants have largely lived in seclusion, keeping as far as possible from the spread of smaller peoples' settlements. From time to time, giants lent their strength to conflicts among other folk. Charismatic giants occasionally forged short-lived kingdoms in ultimately futile efforts to restore the glory of Ostoria, but giants have never again been a driving force in the history of the world as they were during the Dawn Ages.



The Sword Coast of the Forgotten Realms holds many giant-built ruins featuring massive stone monoliths with keyhole-like openings.

Giant Runes and Dwarvish Script

When Annam created the giants, he also taught them language and gave them runes of power. These symbols are pictographs: each symbol represents a whole word or concept rather than a single letter or sound. Each rune holds latent magical power, much like the glyphs inscribed in magic circles of protection, teleportation circles, and magical traps like the *glyph of warding* spell. Thus, the first giants treated these runes as a sacred secret and rarely wrote them.

It wasn't until long after the first flourishing of the giants' culture that the introduction of the Dwarvish script—an alphabetic set of symbols, where each glyph represents a single sound—made transcribing the Giant language an easier task. To this day, most written forms of the Giant language use the Dwarvish script (as described in the *Player's Handbook*), and the knowledge of Giant runes is rare except among those who study magical writing.



Greyhawk

If the giants of Oerth had a mighty empire founded by Annam in the distant past, that fact is not recorded in any of the extant histories of the world. Even so, many giants of Greyhawk revere the sons of Annam, though others have been lured into the service of demon lords or various elder evils.

Dragonlance

During the Age of Dreams, the newly created peoples of Krynn awoke to the first dawn of the world. The first to awaken were a Giant folk known as irda, whose myths claimed they were shaped by the hands of the gods. (Some interpreters of these myths identify the dragon queen Takhisis as their creator, while giant scholars on other worlds believe Annam must have had a part in their creation.) The irda quickly established the first mighty nation of the young world, subjugating humans as their empire grew. The irda ruled for thousands of years, but they fell into decadent cruelty and their empire gradually declined until their human servitors overthrew them.

Eberron

From the ashes of a mythic war between angelic and demonic forces that left the primeval world in ruins, an empire of giants was born on the mysterious continent of Xen'drik. The giants dominated Xen'drik for millennia, ruling over many smaller peoples—including elves who chafed under their rule. When the might of the giants began to wane, the elves rebelled. As the giants prepared to use world-shattering magic to smite the elves, the dragons of far-off Argonnessen attacked Xen'drik and brought about the fall of the giants' civilization.

Some giants still live among the ruins of their ancient civilization, though both their numbers and their sophistication are greatly diminished since the fall of their empire. Other giants left Xen'drik and now live alongside smaller peoples. Giants have been known to study in the universities of the Five Nations, to lead bands of marauders in Droaam, and to trade with dwarf miners far beneath the surface of the Mror Holds.

The giants of Eberron do not tell legends of Annam the All-Father, nor do they adhere to the rigid structure of the ordning. This might be another example of the effects of Eberron's isolation from the rest of the multiverse, but it is also possible that Annam abandoned his children at the fall of their ancient empire, just as he did on other worlds, and they have since forgotten him entirely.

SARAH FINNIGAN

